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Law enforcement at the margin of the law: Information provision and support for militarization in Mexico

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Abstract
Democracies have turned to the militarization of public security as a primary strategy to combat organized crime. Mounting evidence demonstrates that this policy results in the escalation of violence and human rights violations. However, militarization continues to enjoy broad public support. Widespread citizen support poses a challenge to democracy as it can result in the election and empowerment of political leaders favoring militarization, enabling further human rights abuses. We propose and test an information-based theory of change in policy support. We evaluate the effects of increasing the salience of information on state armed actors' frequent collusion with criminal organizations vis-à-vis the human consequences of militarized operations, in addition to the systematic nature of state armed actors' unlawful behavior as reported by human rights organizations. We test our hypotheses in Mexico using an original two-wave online panel survey with a conjoint experiment embedded in the second wave. The findings show that making collusion salient reduces support for militarization, independent of the state armed actor in charge. Exposure to information about lethal violence against innocents also results in overall lower policy support, but not information on the systematic nature of abuses. Further analyses suggest that this null finding results from high tolerance for unlawful state armed actors' behavior, as long as it is perceived to serve the purpose of fighting criminals. However, unlawful behavior that reinforces organized crime, such as collusion, effectively reduces militarization support.

Keywords
Automated text analysis, collusion, Mexico, militarization, public security policy, survey experiment

Introduction

Democracies worldwide are increasingly turning to punitive measures as a cornerstone of their public security strategies. These measures, commonly referred to as 'iron-fist' policies, encompass a range of actions such as increased incarceration and militarized law enforcement – defined as 'the process through which government agencies tasked with providing public safety adopt the weapons, organizational structure, and training typical of the armed forces' (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021: 521). Militarized law enforcement (hereafter referred to as militarization), characterized by heavy reliance on violence in public security operations (Lake, 2022; Tiscornia, 2023), is often adopted to signal toughness in countering perceived domestic threats, including organized crime (Córdova, 2025; González, 2021; Lamb, 2018; Magaloni and Rodriguez, 2020). Militarized

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practices range from police adoption of military-like tactics to the deployment of military forces for public safety purposes.

At the start of 2010, around 75% of countries across the world had adopted some form of militarization, including 60% of democratic countries (De Bruin, 2021). However, mounting evidence underscores that, in the long run, militarization is largely ineffective at enhancing safety. Instead, this policy leads to the escalation of violence and widespread human rights abuses (e.g. Blair and Weintraub, 2023; Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2023; Masera, 2021; Stavro and Welch, 2023). In order to undertake punitive militarized actions, governments often find it necessary to relax accountability mechanisms governing the behavior of police and military forces, thereby permitting the use of excessive violence (Durán-Martínez, 2017; Lessing, 2017; Trejo and Ley, 2020; Yashar, 2018). Increased impunity also enables the participation of police and military personnel in the very criminal activities they are tasked with combating, leading to a 'gray zone' where the behavior of state armed actors intersects with that of criminals (Trejo and Ley, 2020; Trejo et al., 2025). State armed actors often violate the law in collusion with criminal organizations.

Despite its ineffectiveness and adverse effects on human rights and accountability, militarization policy continues to enjoy widespread public support (Gunderson et al., 2021; Mummolo, 2018; Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017). Previous research demonstrates that public approval largely influences the adoption of punitive policies (Enns, 2014; Jennings et al., 2017). Consequently, citizens' preference for militarization poses a threat to democracy by bolstering support for populist authoritarian leaders who advocate for punitive measures (Laterzo, 2023).

Given these concerns, a growing body of research seeks to explain why citizens support the militarization of public security and politicians who advocate for it, notwithstanding its adverse impacts (e.g. Blair and Weintraub, 2023; Enns, 2016; Flores-Macías, 2022; Harig, 2022; Laterzo, 2023; Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017). Beyond delving deeper into the reasons behind citizens' support, our contribution to the existing literature lies in identifying strategies to foster public condemnation of public security approaches that rely on excessive force. *More specifically, we ask, does making information on state armed actors' wrongdoing salient reduce citizen support for militarization policy? If so, what kind of information is the most relevant to reduce policy support? What are the potential mechanisms through which information provision undermines support for militarization?*

We propose that highlighting the unlawful conduct of state armed actors can prompt shifts in policy preference through the provision of two main information contents: (1) making collusion between criminals and state armed actors salient, and (2) highlighting the systematic nature of state armed actors' unlawful behavior. Existing literature suggests that citizen endorsement of repressive policies often stems from the low salience of human costs associated with them (García-Ponce et al., 2023; Masullo and Morisi, 2023). However, researchers have not yet examined how emphasizing information about state–criminal collusion in relation to human costs affects citizens' assessments of militarization policy. Furthermore, there is a gap in understanding about whether raising citizens' awareness that such negative outcomes are not isolated incidents or associated with some individuals ('a few rotten apples'), but part of a systemic pattern of impunity, influences citizens' policy support.

Building upon insights from public opinion research on source cues (e.g. Zaller, 1992) and institutional legitimacy (e.g. Tyler, 2006, 2017), we develop a theoretical framework to elucidate shifts in support for militarization policy stemming from information salience during the process of policy preference formation. We posit that when the salience of information on wrongdoing is low (i.e. it is not readily available in memory), citizens turn to 'source cues' to form policy preferences. That is, in light of widespread concerns about criminality and limited information about the best approach to fight organized crime, citizens may anchor policy preferences on source cues derived from police and military's perceived institutional legitimacy – broadly defined as the view that a given political institution is 'appropriate, proper, and just' (Tyler, 2006: 376). In contrast, when citizens are presented with information about collusion between state armed actors and organized criminal organizations (OCGs), as well as the systematic nature of wrongdoing, they prioritize this information over source cues when forming policy evaluations. More specifically, increasing the salience of wrongdoing by state-armed actors through information provision can undermine their legitimacy, leading to a decline in public support for militarization.

To test our hypotheses, we use data from an original two-wave online panel survey in Mexico with a conjoint experiment embedded in the second wave.[1] The results show that making information on collusion salient reduces support for militarization, and that this effect is associated with a decline in institutional legitimacy, as we posit. However, not all information treatments worked as expected.

Providing information about the recurrence and thus systematic nature of state armed actors' unlawful behavior, as documented by human rights organizations, did not result in substantive attitudinal change, at least on average. Further analysis indicates that this null effect stems from widespread tolerance of unlawful behavior by state-armed actors, as long as it is perceived to serve the goal of combating crime. When operating outside the boundaries of the law involves collusion with criminals – thereby reinforcing crime rather than reducing it – citizens become more inclined to hold state armed actors accountable for their misconduct and express lower support for militarization policies.

Complementing other articles examining citizen attitudes in this volume (Carreras et al., 2025; Masullo et al., 2025), we contribute to this special issue on violence in democracies by emphasizing the challenges militarization policies pose to citizens' democratic principles. Beyond increasing unlawful state violence, reliance on militarization undermines citizens' democratic values, making individuals less likely to condemn human rights violations. However, we demonstrate that highlighting information about unlawful behavior by state-armed actors – particularly state–criminal collusion – can shift public attitudes and foster greater condemnation.

Explaining support for militarization

Militarized law enforcement prioritizes the use of violence in response to security threats, and can involve actions ranging from fostering a 'warrior mentality' in police departments and the creation of specialized police units that emulate the military in behavior, structure, and tactics (Balko, 2013), to the acquisition of military weapons by police departments (Gunderson et al., 2021), and the use of the military for public security (Blair and Weintraub, 2023). As such, militarization involves a wide range of practices that vary along a continuum (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021; Tiscornia and Pérez Bentancur, 2022).

Militarization practices have been endorsed by both politicians and citizens. As part of the broader phenomenon of punitive populism (Bonner, 2019), elected presidents have embraced slogans such as 'shoot to kill' in Duterte's Philippines, and 'a good bandit is a dead bandit' in Bolsonaro's Brazil, with surveys indicating that at least 50% of Brazilians endorsed such statements (Jardim, 2018). Moreover, data from Latin America reveal widespread public support for the involvement of the armed forces in combating crime – despite legal provisions that prohibit such practices. Countries like Brazil, Mexico, Honduras, and El Salvador report some of the highest rates of citizen endorsement for this approach (LAPOP, 2014). Not surprisingly, fueled by popular support, the vast majority of countries in Latin America have turned to the militarization of public security as the primary response to organized crime (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021). In Mexico, in addition to more common militarization practices, the government also created a specialized police unit, the National Guard (NG), which shares many of the features of the military's organization and procedures.

In light of increasing militarization and high citizen support across the world, scholars have explored the determinants of citizens' punitive attitudes. Studies have indicated that authoritarian attitudes rooted in child-rearing practices serve as robust predictors of support for militarization(Azpuru and Malone, 2019), while other have found that crime victimization drives support for punitive policies (García-Ponce et al., 2023; Visconti, 2020). Conversely, research has demonstrated that support for such policies often transcends various political and demographic factors, including ideology and income (e.g. Gunderson, 2022; Laterzo, 2023).

Previous research has also identified perceived legitimacy as an important predictor of militarization support. For example, when it comes to support for military involvement in public security provision, Pion-Berlin and Carreras (2017) argue that citizens make a 'comparative judgement call' about the effectiveness of the police vis-à-vis the military. Along similar lines, Blair et al. (2023) suggest that 'blame shifting' from the military to the police may help explain persistent support for ineffective militarized security policies. Taken together, these studies suggest that a higher regard for the military compared to the police may help explain support for the direct involvement of the military in public security, as well as support for police forces emulating military practices. Indeed, evidence from across the world shows that the military's legitimacy, as measured by political trust, typically exceeds that of the police and other major political institutions (Accorsi and Krebs, 2024). By implication, in most countries, citizens are more likely to support militarization policies led by the military than the police.

Recent research also indicates that citizens are concerned with the human cost of militarized interventions. This suggests that when such information becomes salient, individuals may not rely solely on the implementer's legitimacy to determine their policy support. Yet, citizens weight potential human rights violations during anti-crime militarized operations differently, depending on the perceived innocence of victims. For example,

García-Ponce et al. (2023) conclude that citizens are inclined to support extreme levels of violence as long as targets are depicted as criminals. Similarly, Masullo and Morisi (2023) find that support for militarization decreases when military operations result in violence against civilians, but not when victims are depicted as members of drug cartels. Congruent with these findings, when a victim of human rights abuses is labelled a terrorist, citizens are less inclined to mobilize in her favor and demand justice (Bracic and Murdie, 2020).

Drawing upon prior research, we advance an information-based theoretical framework of shifts in support for militarization policies. Diverging from existing studies, we explore whether the impact of exposure to information regarding human costs hinges not only on the innocence of victims but also on the identity of the state armed actor involved (military or police) and the nature of the violence perpetrated (lethal or non-lethal). Further, we examine the effects of information salience on two underexplored patterns of state actors' conduct in militarized environments: collusion with criminal networks and the systematic nature of unlawful behavior.

An information-based theory of changes in support for militarization policy

The ability of citizens to assess policies based on accurate information about their content and consequences is fundamental to the effective functioning of democracy. However, when asked to express opinions on policy issues, citizens often lack accurate policy information in memory or the motivation to retrieve it (e.g. Chen and Chaiken, 1999). That is, individuals might not have policy knowledge or, even if they do, such knowledge might not be the most salient (i.e. not readily available in memory). In such scenario, citizens turn to heuristics or 'top of the head' cues to evaluate policies (Zaller, 1992). In this process, 'source cues' (i.e. references to prominent political actors or institutions) and citizens' perceptions of the legitimacy of those sources become crucial for determining the extent to which they support a given policy. Public opinion is thus influenced by the perceived expertise or credibility of the source or institution responsible for policy implementation (Mondak, 1993, 1994: 171). Furthermore, perceptions of effectiveness play a crucial role in shaping perceptions of institutional legitimacy, as well as political trust, one of its core components.

As Hetherington and Globetti (2002: 254) write, 'if, other things equal, people perceive the architect of policies untrustworthy, they will reject its policies; if they consider it trustworthy, they will accept them'. Thus, making policy implementers' identities salient can lead to a policy 'endorsement effect' (Zaller, 1992: 33), even in the absence of readily available information on policy provisions and its likely outcomes. For example, previous research indicates that higher courts posses a 'legitimacy-conferring capacity' when they issue decisions and policies (e.g. Sternberg et al., 2022), while perceptions of police legitimacy also play a significant role in delegating decisions on public security to law enforcement (e.g. Tyler, 2004).

Research suggests that citizens base their assessments of police or military legitimacy on perceived effectiveness. Police legitimacy largely stems from perceptions that the police can credibly prevent crime, either through deterrence or coercion (Tyler, 2004: 90). Similarly, favorable evaluations of military legitimacy relative to the police often depend on citizens' perceived differences in the performance of these two institutions (Blair et al., 2023; Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017).

Building on these arguments, we propose that when accurate information on militarization policy (its effectiveness and consequences) is not readily available in memory, citizens will base their policy opinions on source cues derived from the perceived legitimacy of the policy implementer (i.e. either the police or the military). As such, in a scenario of low information salience, individuals who perceive a given state armed actor as effective in combating crime are likely to view their methods, including militarization practices, favorably – despite evidence that such practices are largely ineffective in the long term and often result in massive human rights abuses. We illustrate our theoretical framework in Figure 1.

We posit that a significant proportion of the population may fall in scenario I in Figure 1 – even in contexts where militarization policies result in widespread state armed actors' unlawful behavior. Individuals who are inattentive or have low political interest may not follow news about reports from human rights organizations. Alternatively, such news may receive less coverage in the mass media. Moreover, since state repression primarily targets marginalized communities affected by crime, many individuals may lack direct experiences with state violence. Importantly, even when citizens are aware of the dangers of militarization, the urgency of combating organized crime may become the most salient factor influencing their perspective. In summary, living in a highly militarized context does not automatically make state armed actors' unlawful behavior the most salient

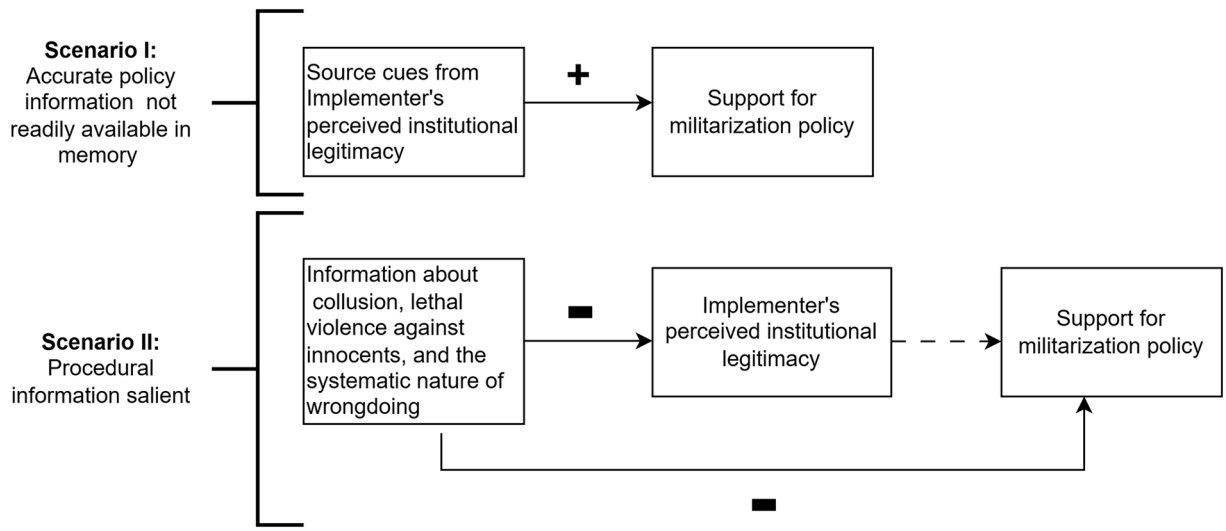

Figure 1. Theory building: explaining changes in support for militarization.

information in citizens' memory. Therefore, we posit that in the first scenario, cues from the implementer's institutional legitimacy or perceived effectiveness in combating crime will positively predict support for militarization, as indicated by the solid arrow.

Furthermore, since citizens in most countries view the military as more legitimate than the police (e.g. Accorsi and Krebs, 2024), we expect that support for the militarization of public security will be higher when the military, rather than the police, is the source cue or policy implementer being primed. More generally, we anticipate that source cues with higher legitimacy will generate greater support. Therefore, we test the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1: Support for militarization increases when iron-fist operations are conducted by state armed actors with comparatively higher institutional legitimacy.

Heuristic models of information processing rely on the assumption that citizens evaluate policies based on 'the principle of least effort' (Chen and Chaiken, 1999: 74). In our case, this suggests that citizens rely on source cues stemming from institutional legitimacy to evaluate policy when additional information is not salient, thereby avoiding the cognitive effort of retrieving further details from memory. Alternatively, the heuristic-systematic or dual processing model suggests that when individuals are presented with policy information prior to forming a judgment, they incorporate it into their opinion-forming process (Bullock, 2011; Chen and Chaiken, 1999). However, some kinds of policy information are more influential than others to shape policy preferences (e.g. Nicholson, 2011). Relevant to our case, citizens value information about *procedural justice* – the processes through which criminal justice institutions achieve their outcomes – rather than focusing solely on the outcomes themselves (Mazerolle et al., 2012; Tyler, 1990, 2004). Thus, as illustrated in the second scenario in Figure 1, when information about the behavior of state armed actors and the procedures they employ to achieve outcomes is readily available, citizens also consider this information when assessing actors' legitimacy (Tyler and Huo, 2002) and their subsequent level of policy support.

What type of procedural information might lower support for militarization? We argue that exposing individuals to information about state armed actors' collusion with criminal organizations – a practice that largely explains the empowerment of organized crime – can lead to attitudinal change. While individuals may view human harm as an inevitable cost of criminal wars (Masullo and Morisi, 2023) – making them more willing to tolerate or even endorse such harm when the victims are alleged criminals – collusion clearly undermines the goal of ending criminal violence. We examine the impact of information about collusion compared to human costs, particularly when these involve lethal violence against innocents. While previous literature suggests that the perceived innocence of the victim is important, it remains unclear whether this effect varies depending on the type of violence. Considering citizens' well-documented high tolerance for human rights violations, we expect that highlighting instances of lethal violence against innocents will lower support for militarization at a higher rate compared to cases of non-lethal violence.

Nevertheless, when individuals are exposed to the outcomes of a specific militarized operation, they may perceive state armed actors' wrongdoing as isolated incidents, attributed to a few 'rotten apples', rather than 'rotten orchards' (Punch, 2003). This perception can diminish citizens' inclination to hold institutions accountable, leading them to prefer individual sanctions instead. Therefore, we propose highlighting information that underscores the systematic nature of unlawful behavior – for example, as documented by human rights advocates. This information can increase citizens' willingness to attribute responsibility to institutions rather than individuals, ultimately leading to lower levels of institutional legitimacy and reduced support for militarization. We formulate the following additional hypotheses:

Hypothesis 2: Making information about state armed actors' collusion with criminals salient (i.e. readily available in memory) will reduce support for militarization policy.

Hypothesis 3: Making information about the human cost of militarized operations salient, particularly lethal violence against innocent individuals, will reduce support for militarization policy.

Hypothesis 4: Making information salient about the systematic nature of state armed actors' unlawful behavior, as documented by human rights organizations, will reduce support for militarization policy.

As illustrated in the second scenario in Figure 1, we theorize that when citizens receive procedural information, their support for militarization will decline as a result of updated perceptions of institutional legitimacy. More specifically, we posit that an important channel through which we should observe a decline is via reduced institutional legitimacy, as manifested in lower perception of militarized interventions' effectiveness as well as the adequacy of the procedures followed.

A remaining question pertains to whether changes in institutional legitimacy will depend on the identity of the policy implementer, with lower declines seen for those with a higher initial level of legitimacy. As depicted in Figure 1, we theorize that source cues' legitimacy will be less influential in shaping public opinion when relevant procedural information is readily available. We represent this effect in Figure 1 with a dashed arrow linking institutional legitimacy and policy support in scenario II. Therefore, we anticipate observing a similar impact of information treatments on policy support across different policy implementers, namely the various state armed actors primed as leading military operations:

Hypothesis 5: Information treatments will lower support for militarization policy at a similar rate across policy implementers, making policy support less dependent on source cues.

Case study: Militarization in Mexico

Mexico provides an ideal case to test our information-based theory for several reasons. First, as in many other countries – such as the United States, France, South Africa, the Philippines, Brazil, and El Salvador – Mexico has primarily relied on militarization policy to address organized crime (Flores-Macías, 2018; Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021). Second, besides relying on a militarized police, the Mexican military has also historically been involved in the provision of public security – with citizens granting a higher degree of legitimacy to the military than the police, as in most countries across the world (Accorsi and Krebs, 2024). Since at least the first half of the 20th century, the military has played a central role in a wide range of public security tasks, from crowd control to crime fighting. They have also exerted control over the police and policing (Kloppe-Santamaría, 2020).

Third, like in other contexts, the increased use of militarized tactics in Mexico has gone hand-in-hand with an increased permissiveness in the abuse of force, with few if any consequences for perpetrators. During President Felipe Calderon's war on drugs (2006–12), thousands of military officers were deployed for public security tasks, resulting in more than 100,000 deaths (Flores-Macías, 2022; Osorio, 2015; Romero et al., 2015; Trejo and Ley, 2020). State armed actors in general, including the military, have been involved in torture and extrajudicial killings (Kloppe-Santamaría, 2020).

The militarization of public security persisted during the administrations of Enrique Pená Nieto (2012–18) and President Andrés Manuel López Obrador (2018–24), continuing to the present. Of note is the creation of the National Guard in 2019, a new security agency that replaced the Federal Police, composed of soldiers and police officers, de facto controlled by the military (Zarkin, 2023). Nevertheless, the ongoing militarization efforts in Mexico have failed to enhance public security (Flores-Macías, 2022), with violence rates still rising. In addition, human rights organizations have continued to report police, military, and National Guard engagement in human rights abuses, including torture (Asmann, 2017; Human Rights Watch, 2023). Notably, a recent study (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2023) documents that complaints increased at a higher rate as the Mexican military became more involved in public security provision.

A fourth crucial aspect underscoring the relevance of the Mexican case is the deep-rooted collusion between the security apparatus and criminal organizations. A pernicious consequence of the lack of accountability is the creation and expansion of the gray zone of criminality: the widespread involvement of state armed actors in criminal activities and/or collusion with organized criminal networks (Trejo and Ley, 2018, 2020; Trejo et al., 2025). As Trejo and Ley (2020) explain, Mexico's politics is deeply linked to the illicit drug trade. This connection was strengthened when the Mexican government began deploying militarized police units and the military as part of a federal program to dismantle drug trafficking (Trejo and Ley, 2020: 70–71). As a result, as early as the 1970s, the Mexican security apparatus began administering and reorganizing the drug trade, with significant profits from colluding with criminal organizations. After the democratic transition in 2000, these links persisted as the military and police were not investigated or prosecuted for colluding with criminal organizations (Trejo et al., 2025).

Headlines reporting incidents such as 'drug lords hunt corrupt police officers who stole shipment in Tijuana' (Associated Press, 2023) are not exclusive to Mexico, but also mirror those found in other countries: 'nine law enforcement officers sentenced for protecting drug dealers' in the United States (US Attorney's Office, 2014) and 'members of the Military involved in different crimes' in El Salvador (Lemus, 2023) exemplify a multitude of cases that have surfaced beyond Mexico.

Given all these features, Mexico constitutes a relevant case for testing our information-based theory of attitudinal change. Our theoretical framework suggests that, even in contexts like Mexico, where state armed actors have a long history of widespread involvement in unlawful behavior, this history may not be the most salient in citizens' minds when asked to evaluate militarization policy. Instead, the urgency to eradicate organized crime at any cost often takes precedence, particularly if the military carry out interventions. Evidence that readily accessible information about state armed actors' unlawful behavior can shift entrenched support for militarization policy in Mexico highlights a similar potential for change in contexts with lower levels of criminal violence. This implies that effective information strategies in challenging cases, where success appears unlikely, may have broader applicability across different contexts.

Research design

To test our hypotheses, we rely on a two-wave online panel survey in Mexico, representative of the population with access to the internet – namely, 80% of the population (Villalobos, 2024).[2] The panel was fielded between 20 December 2023 and 12 January 2024. The baseline survey (N = 3,024) allowed us to examine citizens' awareness of state armed actors' wrongdoing, as well as perceived institutional legitimacy and its correlation with support for militarization policy. To assess whether citizens change their level of policy support when relevant procedural information becomes salient, we implemented a pre-registered conjoint experiment in the second wave of the panel survey (N = 2,061). Embedding the experiment in the second wave allowed us to avoid priming effects likely to occur from pre-treatment variables embedded in the same survey (Klar et al., 2020).

The survey experiment was fielded one week after the baseline survey, and consisted of an original vignette that depicts a hypothetical, yet realistic, militarized operation in a neighborhood. Our goal was to emulate the way in which respondents would encounter this information in real life, probably in a newspaper. Each respondent was presented with four randomly selected versions of the vignette and asked to complete a series of questions after reading each of them, resulting in a total of 8,092 observations. The English translation of the vignette is shown below (randomized text appears in bold).[3] Table 1 summarizes the experimental attributes and their respective levels.

'As part of the Mexican government's public security policy, many heavily armed **[police/National Guard/Army]** agents arrived in a neighborhood looking for members of an organized crime group. Officers found unlicensed firearms and detained four suspects. **[no information/During the operation, officers killed two other suspects/During the operation, officers killed two innocent residents/ During the operation, officers injured two other suspects/During the operation, the officers injured two innocent residents]. [no information/Two weeks later, it was discovered that some of the officers involved in the operation had sold the firearms without a license to the detained suspects]. [no information/National and international non-governmental organizations have documented that armed officers of the Mexican government who participate in this kind of operations frequently act at the margin of the law]**.'

In the vignette we present a militarized operation in which a 'successful' outcome is always achieved, 'officers

Table 1. Experimental attributes and levels.

Attributes	*Levels*
Source cue	Police; Military; National Guard
Collusion	No information provided.
	Two weeks later, it was discovered that some of the officers involved in the operation had sold the unlicensed firearms to the detained suspects.
Human cost	No information provided.
	Lethal violence: During the operation, the officers **killed two other suspects**/During the operation, the officers also **killed two innocent residents**.
	Non-lethal violence: During the operation, the officers **injured two other suspects**/During the operation, the officers **injured two other innocent residents**.
Systematic unlawful behavior	No information provided.
	National and international non-governmental organizations have documented that armed officers of the Mexican government who participate in this kind of operations frequently act at the margin of the law.

found unlicensed firearms and detained four suspects'. As a result of this design choice, the vignette tests whether making procedural information salient can offset likely perceptions of the operation's effectiveness. The wording intentionally refers to suspects and not criminals, which allows us to examine whether, even when using ambiguous language, citizens might still support militarization policies. We also intentionally chose to refer to *many heavily armed* actors to denote the militarized nature of the operation. The preference for the use of violence to handle crime is a core marker of militarization, which in practice often materializes in the deployment of a large number of police or military troops carrying heavy weapons seeking to detain individuals. The public display of force is important for depicting a 'tough on crime' image and thus achieving public support. In short, our vignette depicts a conventional militarized operation implemented in a broader context of militarized public security, presenting the operation as 'part of the Mexican government's public security policy'. To gauge support for militarization policy, our main outcome of interest, after reading the vignette respondents were asked: On a scale of 1 to 7, where 1 means 'not at all' and 7 'a lot', to what extent do you support the public security policy of the Mexican government?

Our theory posits that changes in policy support will occur via variation in institutional legitimacy. Accounting for previous research (e.g. Tankebe et al., 2016), we measure institutional legitimacy using adapted survey items associated with three dimensions:

- Perceived effectiveness: How successful do you consider the operation carried out by (police/National Guard/military) in this neighborhood? (1–7 scale)
- Perceived procedural fairness (i.e., appropriateness of procedures): How much do you agree with the following statement? 'The use of violence by (police/National Guard/military) is the best way to combat organized crime'. (1–7 scale)
- Political trust: To what extent do you trust the (police/National Guard/military)? (1–7 scale)

Following each vignette, items on policy support and institutional legitimacy were presented in random order.

Baseline perceptions of state armed actors

What is salient in people's minds?

We begin by examining baseline data to identify the aspects of state armed actors that are on top-of-mind. We randomly assigned individuals to open-ended questions asking about the first two words that came to mind when they thought about the police, National Guard, or the military. Using the answers to those questions, we carried out automated text analysis using the Quanteda R package. First, we identified the ten positive and negative words mentioned most frequently. Table 2 summarizes the results, presenting the list of words rank ordered from highest to lowest frequency.

Notably, the positive term used more often to describe the police and the National Guard is 'vigilant', whereas the military are associated with 'honor'. Further, while 'corruption' is the first negative word that comes to mind more often when describing the police and National Guard (NG), 'violence' is frequently used when describing the military. The term 'criminal' only appears for the police, although in last place.

Second, to compare differential word associations, we performed a relative frequency analysis (i.e. keyness analysis) (Sönning, 2024). This analysis compares frequencies across groups (as opposed to identifying frequencies within groups), which allows us to explore which institution is evaluated more positively. Figures A.1 to A.3 in the Online Appendix present the keyness metrics. Our analysis confirms that when asked what

Table 2. Most frequently used positive and negative terms.

Institution	*Most positive*	*Most negative*
Police	Vigilant, honesty, valor, calm, protector, honor, competent, moral, apt	Corrupt, abuse, violence, accident, incompetence, injustice, fraud, deficient, falsehood, criminal
Military	Honor, valor, honesty, patriotism, sovereignty, vigilance, defend, heroes, admirable	Violence, abuse, corrupt, pain, incompetent, trauma, negative, evil, ignorance, nepotism
National Guard	Vigilant, honesty, valor, guardian, excellent, protector, honor, values	Corrupt, abuse, incompetent, violence, injustice, conflict, deficient, accident, irrelevant, ignorant

comes to mind first when thinking about each institution, citizens are more likely to use positive words to describe the military, followed by the National Guard (NG) and lastly the police. While some of the 'top of the head' words used distinctively to describe the military and the National Guard are 'discipline' and 'security', citizens more often think about 'corruption' when the police are invoked.

While this set of initial analyses reveals the adjectives most salient in describing each institution, it does not indicate *the extent to which* individuals associate state armed actors with wrongdoing. To complement the text analysis, we examined responses to a closed-ended question measuring the degree to which citizens believed that each state armed actor is involved with criminal organizations. As indicated above, spontaneous references to 'criminality' only appear when describing the police, but did not surface as one of the most salient associations. We find that, when asked directly, 42% of respondents strongly believe that the police are involved with organized crime, contrasted with around 15% in the case of the National Guard and the military. When we examined closed-ended questions on citizens' baseline perceptions of state armed actors' excessive use of force, the results are similar to those for collusion (see Figures A.11–A.16).

Overall, these results suggest that information about state armed actors' collusion and excessive use of force is not the most salient to many citizens, particularly when it pertains to the military and the National Guard. This raises an important question: why is this the case, despite reports from human rights organizations documenting unlawful behavior by all state armed actors? One possibility is that the mass media does not make these issues salient enough in comparison to other topics. As a first approximation to this question, we explored whether individuals following the news more frequently perceive higher levels of state–criminal collusion, controlling for other relevant factors (see Figure A.5).

We find that a higher degree of news exposure is significantly associated with a higher perception of police collusion, but it does not predict perceived collusion by the military or National Guard. The results are similar when we run a model with perceived excessive use of force as a dependent variable (see Figure A.6). Importantly, victimization experiences in the hands of a state armed actor do predict perceived excessive use of force. Therefore, individuals who have experienced state violence may be more critical of militarization policies at the baseline. However, our theory suggests that information treatments could further reduce policy support among these individuals – at the baseline, competing factors, such as the perceived urgency to combat crime, may still lead some victims of state violence to maintain a degree of support for militarization, particularly if the military is in charge.

Taken together, these results suggest that, despite well-documented state armed actors' unlawful behavior, this information is not 'on the top of the head' to the majority of citizens. We contend that interventions offering procedural information about wrongdoing and its systematic nature can help individuals form opinions on militarization policies grounded in factual evidence rather than relying primarily on the perceived legitimacy of source cues.

Institutional legitimacy at the baseline

Lastly, using political trust as a proxy measure of legitimacy (1–7 scale), we find support for the expectation that respondents attribute higher legitimacy to the military (mean = 4.92), followed by the National Guard (mean = 4.51) and the police (mean = 3.1).[4] Further, in line with our theory, we expected perceived legitimacy to strongly predict support for militarization, as measured by involvement of the army in anti-crime operations.[5] To examine this proposition, we estimate a linear regression model that included trust in each institution as independent variables, and a series of covariates capturing competing explanations of support for militarization policy.[6] Figure 2 plots the regression results.[7] We find that the more individuals trust the military and the

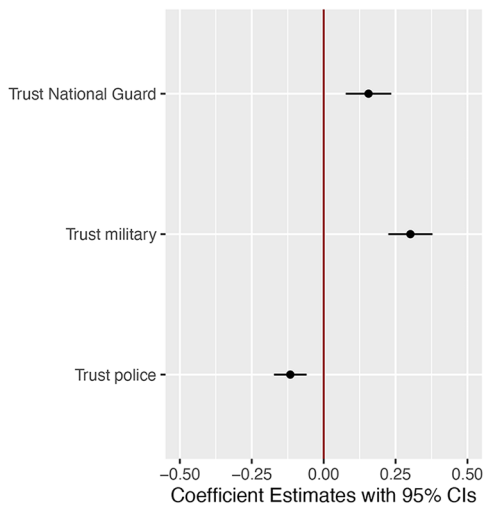

Figure 2. Support for military involvement in public security.

National Guard, the more they tend to support a militarized approach to public security. However, the reverse appears to be true for the police, lending support to previous studies suggesting that preferences for military involvement result from perceived police ineffectiveness (Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017).

Experimental results

Testing hypotheses H1–H4

To test our hypotheses, we estimate the average marginal component effect (AMCE) associated with each information treatment, as well as marginal means (MMs).[8] AMCEs measure *the causal impact or degree to which* a given level within attributes increases or decreases the dependent variable relative to a baseline category (Leeper et al., 2020). AMCEs are distinct from marginal means (MMs) – the latter reflect absolute average levels of the dependent variable associated with a given experimental condition. Figure 3 reports AMCEs. We present MMs in the Online Appendix (A.7). The dependent variable corresponds to the question measuring support for the government's militarized public security policy (on a 1–7 scale).

Consistent with H1, the source primed significantly influences policy support. When respondents were told that the police were in charge, their average support declined about 6 percentage points, compared to a situation depicting the military as the policy implementer. By contrast, when the National Guard was primed, there was no meaningful change relative to the military. As H2 anticipated, we also find that making information about collusion with criminal organizations salient leads to lower policy support relative to a condition where this information is absent – resulting in a 7.14% decline. The findings also support H3; making information on human costs salient is mainly relevant when innocents are the targets of violence, especially lethal violence. Compared to a no-information condition, providing information about lethal violence against innocents resulted in a 8.4% decrease in policy support.

Contrary to our expectations (H4), we do not find evidence that making information about state armed actors' systematic engagement in unlawful behavior results in changes in policy support.

Why does information on 'systematic' unlawful behavior not shift policy support?

One possibility is that the reference to human rights organizations (HROs) in our vignette makes this information treatment less credible. If citizens do not have high regard for HROs, they will not find the information compelling. To explore this possibility, we use an item in the baseline survey gauging attitudes toward HROs, and examine whether this null effect is driven by individuals with more negative views toward HROs. We do not find evidence suggesting that this is the case. On the contrary, we find that individuals who were the most skeptical of HROs at the baseline expressed slightly lower support for militarization policies after exposure to HROs' reporting of systematic wrongdoing (Figure A.17). To better understand this counterintuitive effect, we examined the correlates of attitudes toward HROs. We found that those holding more negative pre-treatment views of HROs were also less supportive of the incumbent president López Obrador, a self-proclaimed left wing supporter of HROs. Therefore, at the baseline, individuals expressing both less regard for HROs and the president also had lower support for the president's public security policy. In short, the results suggest that when those critical of HROs were exposed to the treatment and learned that HROs were not siding with the incumbent government but exposing the systematic abuses of state armed actors, their level of policy support decreased further.

Another possibility for this null finding is that because information on the systematic nature of abuses is introduced last in the vignette, individuals were already exposed to information on wrongdoing from the other treatments. However, we do not find that this is the case either. When we limit the sample to individuals who were not exposed to any other prior information treatment, the null effect of exposure to information about systematic abuse persists (Figure A.18).

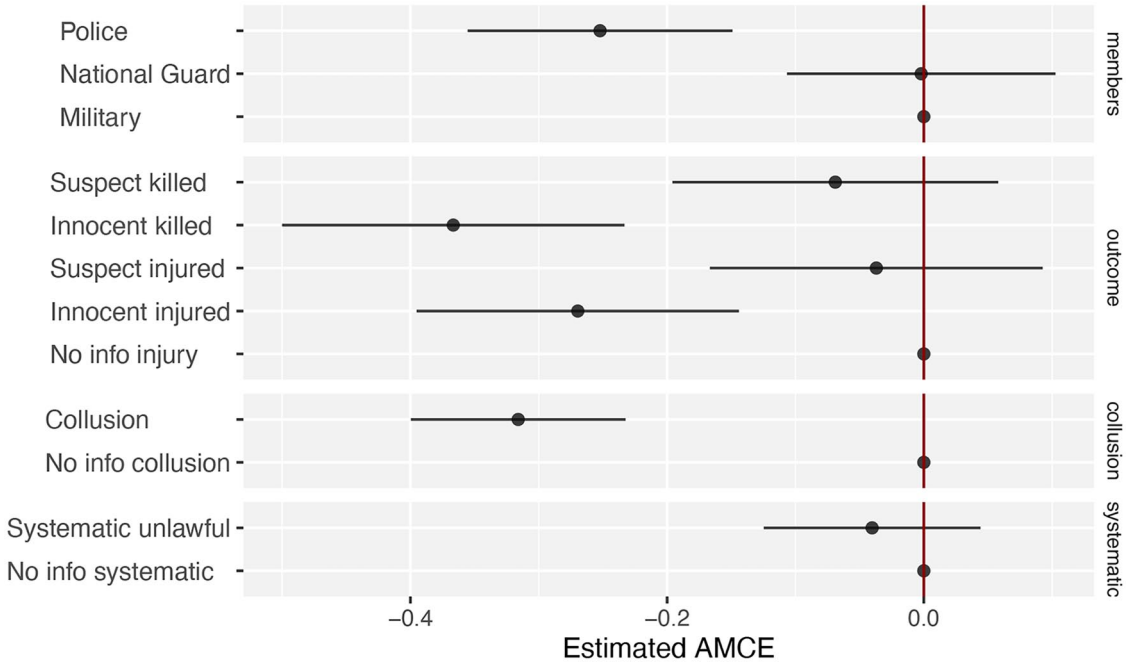

Figure 3. Experimental results: Effects on support for militarization policy.

Given these results, we identified an alternative explanation. Citizens are willing to tolerate systematic human right abuses as long as these might be committed against potential suspects, and thus as long as such abuses are perceived as beneficial to combat crime. Given that the information treatment on systematic abuse does not specify the nature of wrongdoing, citizens might perceive these abuses as potentially contributing to reprehending crime suspects. The analysis of baseline data lends support to this explanation. We find that the overwhelming majority of citizens in Mexico approve of the military using excessive force to combat crime 'even if this violates the law' – over 90% of respondents approve this to some extent, which corresponds to a level of approval above 1 on a 1–7 scale (see Figure A.19). Further, approval of the military using excessive force even if unlawful is strongly and positively correlated with support for the use of the military for public security tasks. Therefore, citizens may only be inclined to shift their public security preferences and reduce support for militarization when treatments explicitly identify wrongdoing as unrelated to combating crime – such as collusion with criminals or the infliction of lethal violence on innocents.

Testing hypothesis H5

Our final hypothesis, H5, posits that when individuals are exposed to information highlighting unlawful behavior, the influence of source cues on support for militarization policy will diminish, regardless of the identity of the armed actor leading the militarized operation. Figure 4 examines whether the magnitude of treatment effects depends on whether the police, National Guard, or military were primed as the actor in charge. As the figure shows, a difference in AMCEs test across policy implementers does not result in significant effects, lending support to H5. The magnitude of the negative impact of making information on collusion with criminals or lethal violence against innocents salient does not vary significantly across the three state armed actors primed (see the last two panels in Figure 4). We conclude that these information treatments reduce support for militarization policy to a similar extent across state armed actors. This is remarkable given the high regard for the military at the baseline, which highlights the significance of these information treatments.

Institutional legitimacy as a mechanism?

As Figure 5 shows, we find that information treatments that significantly reduce support for militarization also result in a decline in levels of institutional legitimacy – as measured by the perceived appropriateness of the use of violence, policy effectiveness, and institutional trust.

Further, as shown in Figure 6, we do not find statistically significant differences in the effect size of information treatments on institutional trust across policy implementers (police, National Guard, and military).

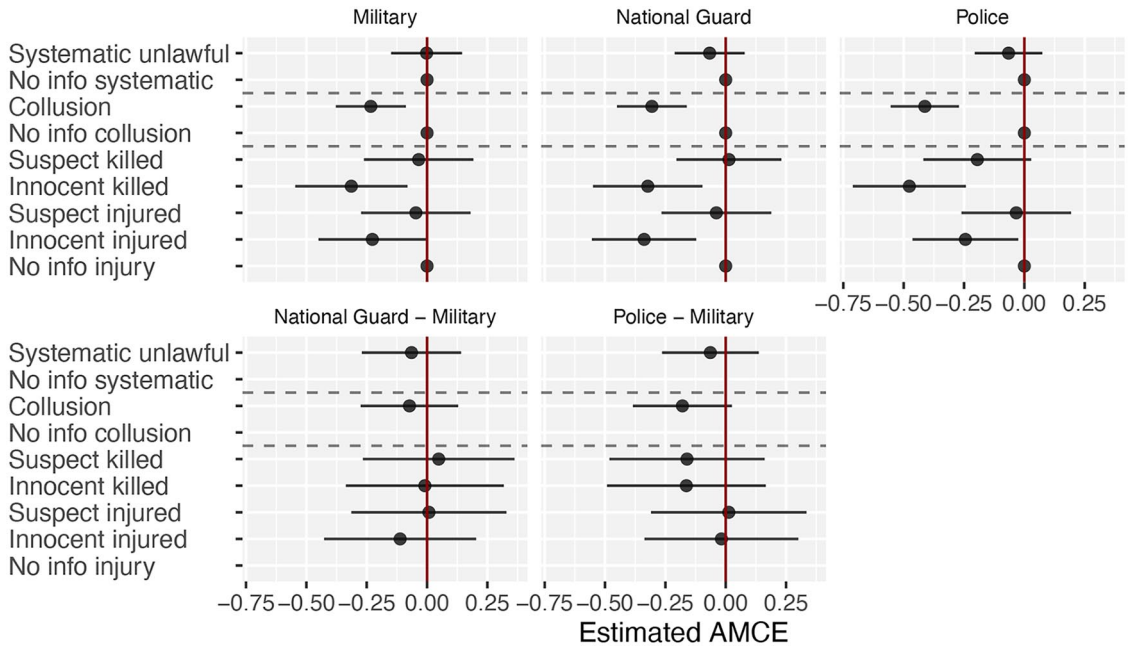

Figure 4. Experimental results: Effects on support for militarization by source cue.

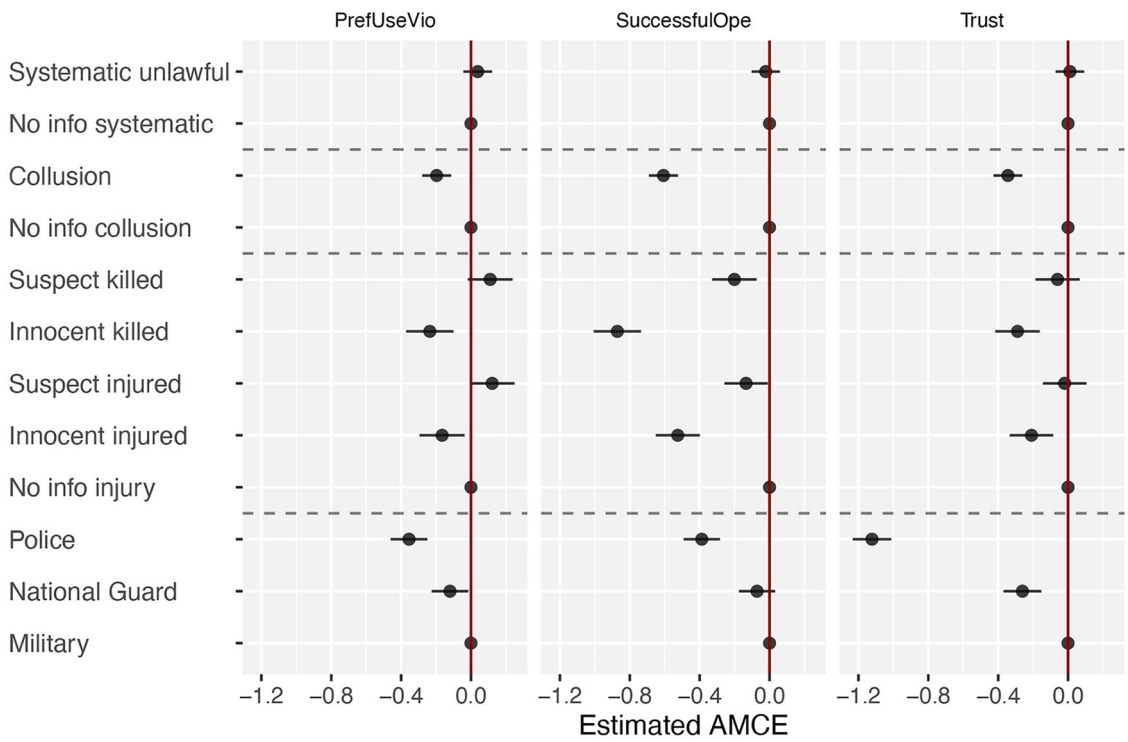

Figure 5. Experimental results: Effects on institutional legitimacy.

However, we observe that when the military are invoked the effect of information provision on lethal violence against innocents is not as strong in comparison to a scenario where the National Guard or the police are in charge of militarized operations. By contrast, information on collusion consistently reduces trust in all institutions in a similar magnitude.

Similarly, information treatments impact the perceived effectiveness of militarized operations and approval of the use of violence equally across state armed

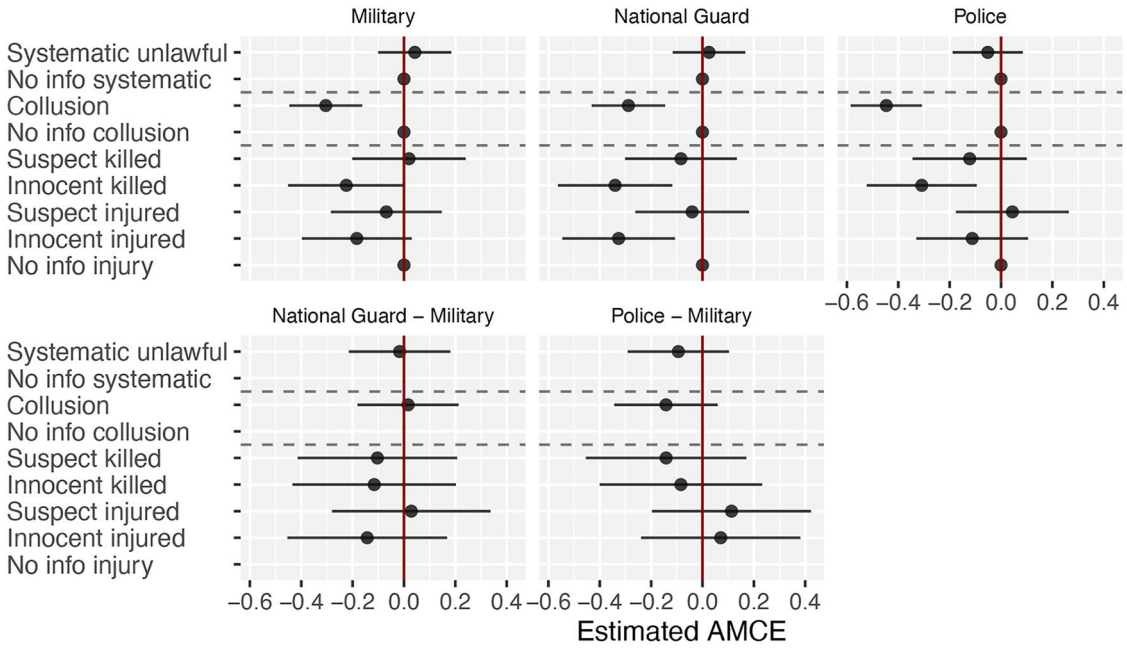

Figure 6. Experimental results: Effects on trust by source cue.

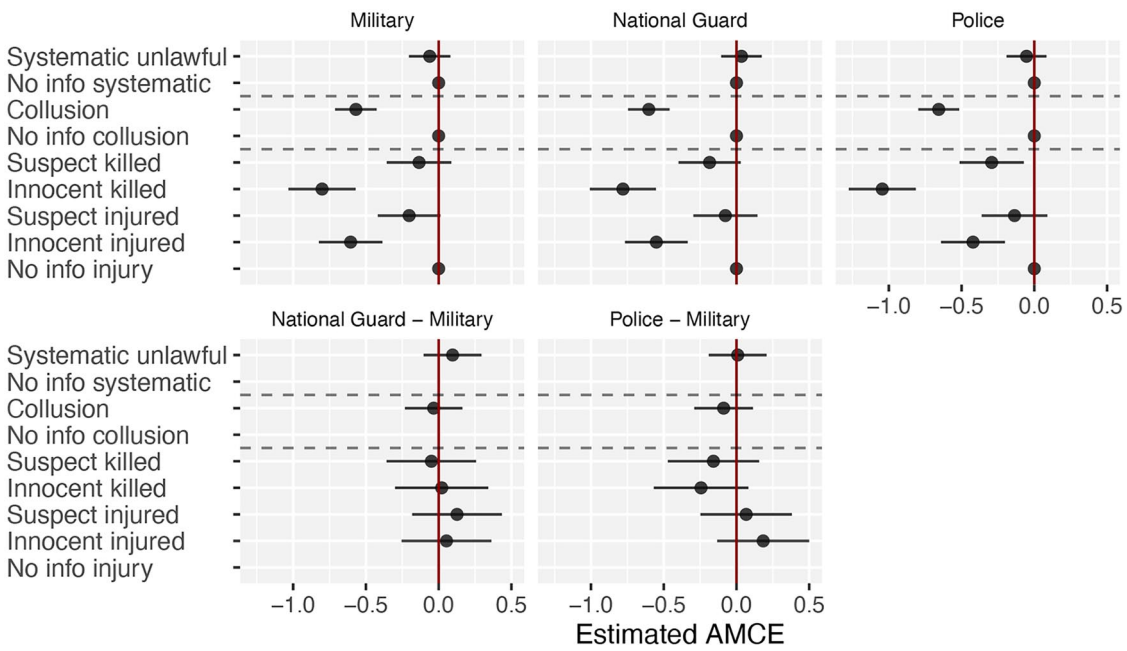

Figure 7. Experimental results: Effects on perceived effectiveness by source cue.

actors (see Figures 7 and 8). We do not find statistically significant differences between AMCE across policy implementers. Despite this finding, we note that invoking the military or the National Guard does not result in a significant decline in preference for the use of violence when information on lethal violence against innocents becomes salient relative to a 'no information' condition. More consistently, information on collusion reduces legitimacy similarly across policy implementers.

Overall, these results suggest that once citizens are exposed to information treatments, particularly to instances of collusion, source cues or the identity of policy implementers become less relevant to determine the extent of state armed actors' legitimacy. This conclusion

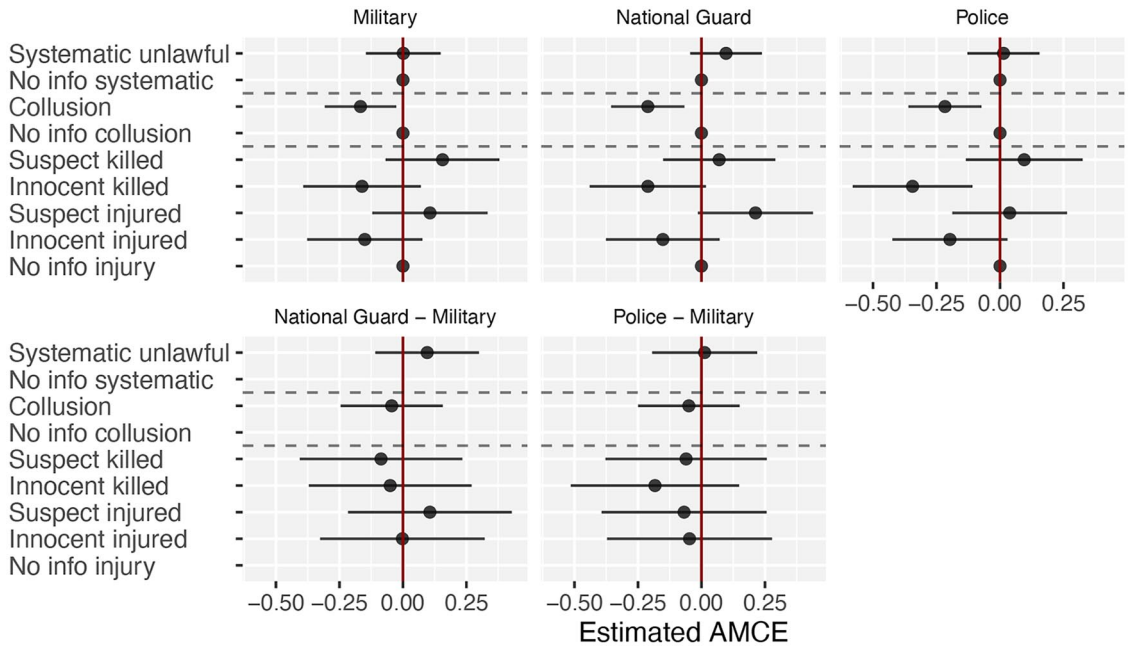

Figure 8. Experimental results: Effects on perceived appropriateness of the use of violence by source cue.

gives us further confidence that changes in policy preferences, which are also less dependent on source cues once individuals are exposed to relevant information, are likely driven by changes in institutional legitimacy, as our theory proposes.

Additional analyses

Evaluating heterogeneous effects

We examine whether the causal impact of information treatments depends on pre-treatment characteristics, including: victimization by organized criminal groups (OCGs) or state armed forces, living in neighborhoods with presence of OCGs, partisan identification, authoritarian personality, gender, socio-economic status, and baseline support for the government's public security policy, as well as pre-treatment support for state armed actors' acting at the margin of the law. To evaluate heterogeneous effects, we followed Leeper et al. (2020), distinguishing between AMCEs and MMs and reporting both estimates graphically in the Online Appendix (A.39–A.62). From these analyses, we draw a main general conclusion: even when MMs show statistically significant differences in levels of policy support between subgroups across experimental conditions, AMCEs indicate that information on collusion or lethal violence against innocents causally lowers policy support at a similar rate across subgroups. For example, we find that despite significantly lower policy support among victims of police violence compared to non-victims (A.42 – A.43), information on collusion or the killing of innocents lowers policy support in both groups at a similar rate (A.44). This finding aligns with our assumption that, even when individuals have first-hand experience with or knowledge of law enforcement's misconduct, their strong concerns about crime may still lead them to support militarization policies to some degree; however, making information on wrongdoing readily accessible in memory can further lower their policy support. Remarkably, we also observe a significant decline among individuals with both relatively high or low initial levels of policy support. Citizens consistently anchored their policy preferences to salient information on state–criminal collusion in particular, regardless of pre-treatment conditions – including baseline support for state armed actors acting at the margin of the law to combat crime. The results further reinforce our earlier observational findings, indicating that information highlighting unlawful behavior unrelated to punishing criminals is more effective in reducing support for militarization.

Evaluating treatment exposure

Given that the design of our conjoint experiment involved completing four tasks, to avoid survey fatigue we did not include a formal manipulation check. Further analyses, however, give us confidence that individuals were successfully exposed to the intended treatment information. We find that individuals who initially

perceived minimal wrongdoing by state armed actors showed reduced support for militarization when exposed to information highlighting collusion or the killing of innocents. If the opposite had occurred – if highlighting this information had failed to reduce support or even increased it among individuals with initially low awareness – we would be less confident that these individuals had become more informed about state armed actors' wrongdoing. To conduct this analysis, we explored heterogeneous effects between subgroups with low and high baseline awareness of police, National Guard, or military collusion with criminal networks, as well as these actors' excessive use of force against civilians (see Figures A.21–A.29).

As predicted by our theory, when no information on collusion is provided, individuals with low baseline perceptions of collusion exhibit higher support for militarization, as evidenced by the marginal means. However, once they are exposed to information on collusion by either state armed actor, this group became significantly less favorable to militarization policy. In other words, when presented with information that offers new insights, their level of policy support decreases. Importantly, we observe a similar effect among individuals with relatively high pre-treatment knowledge of collusion, suggesting that even when citizens are aware of state armed actors' wrongdoing, this information may not be the most salient at the moment of evaluating militarization policies.

Additionally, comparable results emerge when analyzing the impact of information on the killing of innocents among individuals with initially low or high awareness of excessive use of force. Collectively, these findings reinforce our confidence that individuals were successfully exposed to the intended treatments.

Evaluating social desirability bias

Previous studies have found that social desirability bias is more common when researchers employ survey rather than field experiments to evaluate citizens' responses to information exposing them to political elites' unlawful behavior, such as corruption (Incerti, 2020). One might assume that a similar dynamic is explaining our findings. For several reasons, however, our results are unlikely be merely driven by social desirability.

First, conjoint experiments like ours can help mitigate social desirability (Horiuchi et al., 2022), because even if respondents know that one particular condition violates a social norm, they can justify their answer as a function of the other conditions in a given vignette or task. Second, our findings show that not all information treatments exposing individuals to state armed actors' wrongdoing yielded a statistically significant decline in support for militarization policy. This suggests that respondents are not simply providing a socially desirable answer, but discriminating between different types of information. Third, the baseline survey included an item from the Marlowe–Crowne Social Desirability Scale (Lambert et al., 2016). When we split our sample into a low and high propensity to social desirability using this item, we find that the results for each subgroup mimic those presented in Figure 3, further suggesting that our findings are not merely the result of social desirability bias.

Conclusion

As part of a special issue on political violence in democracies, our article sheds light on why governments in contexts plagued by organized crime frequently resort to militarization policies, which often result in unlawful violence and widespread impunity for human rights violations. Our research underscores citizens' strong support for militarization policies as a key factor driving this tendency. We focused on investigating the sources of this support and exploring strategies to effectively encourage a shift in citizens' policy preferences supportive of democratic principles.

Why do citizens endorse militarization policies? Drawing from the case of Mexico, the results indicate that citizens favor greater involvement of the military in public security when they hold negative views of the police. Given the military's higher legitimacy, citizens are more likely to support deploying the military for public security tasks. Furthermore, the findings indicate that militarized operations are likely to maintain broad public support as long as they are perceived as effective in combating organized crime, even when these operations involve significant human rights violations and have demonstrated long-term ineffectiveness in enhancing citizen security. The experimental results show that disseminating general information about state armed actors 'frequently acting outside the law' does not lead to a change in policy support or lower levels of institutional legitimacy.

By contrast, exposing individuals to specific information making salient that state armed actors' wrongdoing does not contribute to combat crime results in lower support for militarization policy. More specifically, increasing the salience of information about state armed actors' frequent collusion with organized criminal groups results in attitudinal change. Similar to previous studies, we also find that citizen awareness of violence

inflicted against innocents during militarized operations reduces policy support. However, this is mainly the case when such violence is lethal. Indicating that violence (lethal or non-lethal) exerted against suspects of crime does not generate a shift in policy support.

In short, our unique empirical contribution is to have unveiled the significant effect of making state–criminal collusion salient as a strategy to reduce support for militarization. Importantly, we find that making collusion salient results in lower policy support independent of whether the military, the police, or the National Guard is depicted as the institution leading militarized operations. Overall, our results support our information-based theory. Changes in policy support appear to be driven by shifts in institutional legitimacy, leading citizens to rely less on source cues and more on accurate information about state armed actors' procedures when evaluating policy.

The results highlight the critical role of independent media and non-governmental organizations in exposing the frequent involvement of state armed institutions in criminal activities. While revealing such involvement can reduce public support for militarization, human rights advocates face a significant challenge in fostering citizen attitudes that prioritize universal human rights – not just the rights of those perceived as innocent. A growing body of literature suggests that interventions centered on human rights education and victims' personal narratives hold promise as effective tools for fostering citizen support for universal human rights (e.g. Córdova and Skigin, 2024). Yet, the specific content of such interventions narratives that would yield the most significant attitudinal changes in militarization support remains to be elucidated, paving the way for future research.

Replication data

The dataset, codebook, and do-files for the empirical analysis in this article, along with the Online Appendix, are available at https://www.prio.org/jpr/datasets/. All analyses were conducted using R.

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Notes

1. We pre-registered our experiment prior to data collection: https://osf.io/6cpwf/?view_only=3226c70393404edaae3119d9ff60a6fc.
2. More information on the survey is provided in the Online Appendix (Table A1). All tables and figures in the Online Appendix are represented by an 'A' followed by their respective number.
3. See Spanish version here: Table A.3.
4. Figure A.4 shows the frequency distributions.
5. The dependent variable is an item in the survey asking how strongly respondents agree (on a 1–7 scale) that 'the army must participate in the fight against crime and violence in Mexico'.
6. To ease the interpretation, we standardized interval variables.
7. See full model in Table A.2.
8. Sample size statistics across experimental conditions are shown in Table A.4. Following Hainmueller et al. (2014), we carried out diagnostic tests to ensure that key assumptions associated with conjoint experiments hold. Overall, the results show that core assumptions applicable to the design of our conjoint experiment hold (see A.5–A.9). MMs are reported in Figures A.7 to A.10.

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